charlatans was Sir John Mandeville, an Englishman who wrote a book full of fantastical tales called simply *The Travels*. He set off from St. Albans in 1322 and returned to England thirty-four years later claiming to have visited India, China, Java, Sumatra and many other places. Geographers, kings and priests studied the book in detail and it was translated into virtually every important European language. His importance can be gauged from the fact that 300 handwritten copies of *The Travels* have survived in various libraries, four times as many as Marco Polo's book.[3]

Some writers like Giles Milton have argued that Mandeville's stories about the Eastern Mediterranean have an element of truth in them, but it cannot be denied that his writings about Asia are outrageous. He talks of women with dogs' heads, one-eyed giants, geese with two heads, giant snails, men with testicles that dangled between their knees, and cannibal pagans who ate their babies. He embellished the widely-held medieval belief that India was ruled by a powerful Christian king called Prester John. Mandeville tells us that he arrived in India after an arduous overland journey but was pleased to find the rich and populous kingdom of Prester John. He goes to some length to describe the palace and the liberal use of precious stones. We are told that the emperor ruled over a massive kingdom and was waited upon by seven kings, seventy-two dukes and 360 earls—all Christian. Every time he went to battle, he was accompanied by three huge crosses of solid gold. Each cross was protected by 10,000 men-at-arms and 100,000 foot soldiers.[4] All this was lapped up by Europeans pleased to hear that there was a potential Christian ally in the east.

Despite everything, Mandeville's book had a very profound impact on the history of the world. He claimed that his travels had proved that the world was round and his book popularized the idea that it was possible to reach India by sailing west. Columbus planned his 1492 expedition after reading *The Travels*, and explorers like Raleigh read the book very carefully. Thus, one of the greatest discoveries of history was based on an elaborate lie!